

One leading health indicator I find meaningful for Healthy People 2030 is reducing the rate of infant deaths (MICH-02) because I would like to pursue a nursing career working with infants or children. I think this is also an important indicator because infants are dependent on others to safeguard them. It takes the mother, family and community at large to protect the children, making it a larger public health issue. Infant mortality can also be a strong indicator of overall population health since it is influenced by many other social determinants of health such as access to maternal care, education, socioeconomic status and safe environments. This is because infant death is linked to maternal health complications, preterm birth, low birth weight, and sudden infant death syndrome. All of these require access to care and proper preventive resources.

The status of infant mortality has been improving and decreased from 5.8 to 5.6 deaths per 1,000 live births from 2017-2022 (Office of Disease Prevention and Health Promotion [ODPHP], n.d.). However, the goal of 5.0 deaths per 1,000 live births has not been met yet (ODPHP, n.d.). I am curious to see how an increase of 77% of newborns not receiving the Vitamin K shot will impact this data as, Vitamin K deficiency bleeding can be fatal and there is not sufficient recent data to assess the impact. (National Institutes of Health [NIH], 2026).

There is also great racial disparity in infant mortality data where infants with non-Hispanic Black or African American mothers had a rate of 10.9 deaths per 1,000 live births (ODPHP, n.d.). This is nearly double the average. However, infants born to non-Hispanic Asian mothers had the lowest rate of 3.5 deaths per 1,000 live births (ODPHP, n.d.). The data shows that there is undeniable racial disparity that must be addressed to improve outcomes for the non-Hispanic Black or African American population. While it is encouraging to see overall infant mortality has decreased from 2017 to 2022, the infant mortality for the non-Hispanic Black or African American population increased from 10.7 to 10.9 deaths per 1,000 live births (ODPHP, n.d.). This data is critical to identify where gaps exist so that targeted interventions can be developed for the populations most impacted by infant mortality.

National Institutes of Health. (2026, January 13). *Protective vitamin shots for newborns on decline*. <https://www.nih.gov/news-events/nih-research-matters/protective-vitamin-shots-newborns-decline>

Office of Disease Prevention and Health Promotion. (n.d.). *Reduce the rate of infant deaths — MICH-02* [Infographic]. U.S. Department of Health and Human Services.

<https://odphp.health.gov/healthypeople/objectives-and-data/browse-objectives/infants/reduce-rate-infant-deaths-mich-02/infographic>